



AFGHANISTAN

AFGHANISTAN OCCUPIES AN IMPORTANT position between central Asia and the Indian Subcontinent. As a result, the country has been fought over for centuries. It has few paved roads and no railroads, and three-quarters of the land is inaccessible. In 1979 Russian troops occupied the country, though they were forced out by the Islamic *mujahideen*. In 1996 the Taliban took control of Kabul and enforced a strict code of behavior, based on their interpretation of Islam. However, their support for Osama bin Laden, wanted in connection with the destruction of the World Trade Center, led to bombing by the US and victory for the opposition Northern Alliance in 2001.

AFGHANISTAN

Capital city: Kabul
Area: 250,000 sq miles (647,500 sq km)
Population: 23,900,000
Official languages: Dari (Persian), Pashtu
Major religions: Muslim 99%, other 1%
Government: Islamic republic
Currency: New Afghani
Adult literacy rate: 36%
Life expectancy: 43 years
People per doctor: 10,000
Televisions: 13 per 1,000 people

THE TALIBAN

In Pashtu, an Afghani language, Taliban means "religious student," and it was from religious schools in Pakistan and the south of Afghanistan that the Taliban developed its extreme ideology. The Taliban is an Islamic militia that promised Afghans stability in return for one of the most repressive governments in the world. Its support of terrorist groups led to the US helping the Northern Alliance to overthrow them.

Some mujahideen groups are based in the hills of Afghanistan. Mujahideen comes from the Arabic word for "fighter."



CULTURAL DESTRUCTION

In 2001 the Taliban destroyed two of the world's largest statues of Buddha at Bamiyan. Built in AD 5, the tallest of the statues was over 174 ft (53 m) high. The Taliban justified this act by saying Islam forbids the depiction of the human form in art, but many Islamic nations disagreed with what they had done.



The Turkmen nomads in the north of the country live in reddish-brown, dome-shaped tents.



The Pushtoon nomads of the south live in black tents spread low over the ground.



TENTS

Some Afghans are nomads, or *kochis*, as they are known locally. The different groups can be distinguished by the unique designs of the felt or animal-skin tents they live in, each design having been passed down through countless generations.

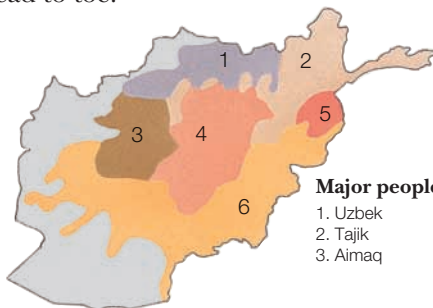


CARPET WEAVING

The Turkmens of northern Afghanistan are skilled carpet makers, hand-knotting and weaving fine wool from the karakul sheep into geometric red, brown, and maroon patterns. The carpets are usually made by women and are used as saddlecloths, tent hangings, and prayer mats.

OPPRESSION OF WOMEN

Under the Taliban, women were denied a full role in Afghan society and were subject to much discrimination. They were not allowed to go to work and girls were banned from school. They were not even allowed to go outside of the home without being accompanied by a male member of their family. When women were permitted outside they had to wear a *burqa* – a traditional Afghani robe that covered them from head to toe.



Major peoples in Afghanistan

1. Uzbek
2. Tajik
3. Aimaq
4. Hazara
5. Nuristani
6. Pushtoon

Find out more

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